MR. LIFE MANAGER · FREE GUIDE

Cleaning Supply Starter List

What to actually buy, what to skip, and roughly what it costs.

BUY The nine that do the work

≈$40–60

WHAT	WHY	ROUGHLY
All-purpose cleaner	Counters, tables, appliances, most surfaces. Your workhorse.	$4–6
Dish soap	Dishes — and a decent spot cleaner besides	$3–5
Bathroom cleaner	Soap scum and mildew need something stronger	$4–6
Toilet bowl cleaner	Plus a brush	$3–5
Glass cleaner	Optional — a damp microfiber does most of it	$3–5
Baking soda	Scrubbing without scratching. Absurdly useful.	$1–2
White vinegar	Descaling, hard water, shower heads, coffee maker	$3–4
★ Microfiber cloths	**The best purchase on this list.** Six to twelve. Replaces most paper towels.	$10–15
Sponges or scrub pads	Replace every 1–2 weeks	$3–5

AISLE What to grab, in the aisle

One trip

No brands here on purpose — they change, they cost more, and the cheap version is usually the same thing. This is what to reach for.

All-purpose cleaner	Any spray bottle that says **all-purpose** or **multi-surface**. Store brand is fine. **Unscented if they have it** — fragrance is what you're paying extra for, and it hides the smell of a surface that isn't actually clean.
Dish soap	The big plain bottle. Concentrated lasts noticeably longer. Any brand.
Bathroom cleaner	Look for **soap scum** or **mildew** on the label — that's the one job an all-purpose won't do well. A spray, not a cream.
Toilet bowl cleaner	The bottle with the angled neck, so it reaches under the rim. Grab the brush at the same time.
Glass cleaner	**Optional.** Try a damp microfiber first — it does most of it. Only buy this if you've tried that and weren't happy.
Baking soda	Baking aisle, not cleaning. A plain box. **Buy the small one** — you'll use less than you think.
White vinegar	Condiment aisle. **Distilled white**, the cheapest big jug. Not cider, not wine vinegar.
Microfiber cloths	**Buy a multipack, not two.** Ten or more. This is the best value on the list and the thing you'll wish you had more of. Color-coding them by room is optional but genuinely useful.
Sponges or scrub pads	A multipack. The kind with a scrubby side. You replace these every week or two, so don't buy nice ones.

TWO RULES FOR THE WHOLE AISLE

Store brand is almost always the same product. Compare the active ingredients if you're curious — usually identical, often half the price.

> **Buy the smallest size of anything new to you.** A bulk jug of something you end up hating is worse than no cleaner at all.

TOOLS One-time buys

≈$50–80

WHAT	NOTES	ROUGHLY
Broom and dustpan		$15–20
Vacuum	A cheap one you'll actually pull out beats an expensive one in a closet	$40–150
Mop and bucket	A flat spray mop is fine for an apartment	$15–30
Rubber gloves	Makes the unpleasant jobs less unpleasant	$3–5
Toilet brush and holder		$5
★ Plunger	**Buy it before you need it.** You will not want to go out for one at 11pm.	$8–12
Trash bags	Check your can size first	$8–12
Paper towels	You'll use far fewer with microfiber	$8–12

LAUNDRY Laundry

≈$25–35

WHAT	NOTES	ROUGHLY
Laundry detergent	Use less than the cap suggests — almost everyone overdoses it	$10–15
Stain remover	Works on fresh stains, rarely on set ones	$4–6
Dryer sheets or wool balls	Wool balls last years	$5–10
Mesh bags for delicates		$5

SKIP Don't buy these — at least not yet

This is the part the cleaning aisle would rather you didn't read.

- × **A separate cleaner for every room**
  Kitchen, living room, and bedroom surfaces are the same surfaces. One all-purpose does it.
- × **Wood-, granite-, and stainless-specific sprays**
  Buy these only when you actually have that surface *and* the general one isn't working.
- × **Disinfecting wipes as your main cleaner**
  Convenient, expensive, wasteful, and worse at actual cleaning. Fine to keep a tub for quick jobs.
- × **Scented everything**
  You're paying for fragrance — and it masks the smell of a surface that isn't clean.
- × **Premium "natural" brands**
  Often the same actives at triple the price. Vinegar and baking soda are the actual budget natural option.
- × **Steam mops, robot vacuums, specialty gadgets**
  Maybe later. Not in month one.

× **Bulk anything, at first**
Buy small until you know what you'll use. Bulk cleaner you hate is worse than no cleaner.

⚠ ONE SAFETY RULE

Don't mix cleaning products. Some combinations — bleach with anything, especially — make fumes that will genuinely hurt you.

One product at a time. Rinse in between. If a surface needs two treatments, rinse with water first. Open a window when you're using anything strong.

That's the whole rule. You don't need to know which combinations are the bad ones if you never mix any of them.

If money is tight

You can clean an entire apartment with four things, for about fifteen dollars:

Dish soap | Baking soda | White vinegar | Microfiber cloths

That covers dishes, counters, glass, scrubbing, and descaling. Not on stone counters — marble, granite, some quartz. If it looks like stone, use dish soap and water. Add a toilet brush and a plunger and you're genuinely fine. Everything else on this page is convenience.

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